



Allied soldiers form lines on the beach at Dunkirk, France, awaiting boats to carry them to England. German air attacks harassed the evacuation.

“WE SHALL FIGHT THEM ON THE BEACHES... WE SHALL FIGHT IN THE FIELDS AND IN THE STREETS, WE SHALL FIGHT IN THE HILLS; WE SHALL NEVER SURRENDER.”

Winston Churchill, British prime minister, addressing Parliament on June 4, 1940



United Commonwealth
A British propaganda poster shows men from the dominions and colonies united in the war effort. Even in 1940 Britain did not “stand alone.”

prime minister by **Paul Reynaud** (1878–1966).

ALTHOUGH BRITAIN AND FRANCE WERE AT WAR WITH GERMANY, the only fighting in Europe in early 1940 was between the **Soviet Union** and **Finland** (see 1939). The British and French governments, both strongly anticommunist, planned to send an expeditionary force to aid the Finns. Troops were assembled, but Soviet military successes led Finland to seek peace in March. In France, the failure to help the Finns led to the fall of the government of **Edouard Daladier**, who was replaced as

Also in March, Soviet dictator **Joseph Stalin** (see 1928) **approved the killing** of all Polish officers who had fallen into Soviet hands through the occupation of western Poland (see 1939). Most of the region's educated elite—doctors, lawyers, and teachers—were also murdered. Some 22,000 victims were buried in **mass graves** in Katyn Forest and elsewhere. In June, when the Soviet Union occupied the Baltic states—Lithuania, Latvia, and Estonia—tens of thousands more

people were executed or deported to labor camps. Stalin's ruthless reach extended as far as Mexico, where his exiled rival **Leon Trotsky** had found refuge. In August, Trotsky was killed by Ramon Mercader, an agent of Stalin's secret police.

On April 4, British prime minister **Neville Chamberlain** announced that Hitler had “missed the bus” by failing to launch a major offensive as **British rearmament accelerated**. Five days after this complacent speech, German forces **occupied Denmark** and **invaded Norway**. Britain and France sent troops and warships to aid the Norwegians but could not prevent a German victory. Norway's King Haakon VII was evacuated to Britain with his government to continue the fight from exile.

In Britain, the disastrous campaign in Norway destroyed confidence in the Chamberlain government. On May 10, **Winston Churchill** became prime minister at the head of a broad coalition.

On the same day, **German forces** invaded the **Netherlands**, **Belgium**, and **Luxembourg**. After Rotterdam was heavily bombed, the Dutch forces surrendered to avoid further destruction. Dutch Queen Wilhelmina defiantly set up a government-in-exile in London.

Allied troops in northern France advanced into Belgium to meet the German offensive. The Germans unexpectedly delivered a powerful thrust **through the Ardennes region into France** and broke through the French defenses at Sedan. Fast-moving German



Battle of France
After the Dunkirk evacuation of the Allied forces, German troops advanced into central and western France.

KEY
 — German advance
 — Allied front line May 21
 — Allied front line May 16
 — Allied defensive line May 28
 — Allied front line Jun 12

formations of tanks and motorized infantry supported by Stuka dive-bombers drove northward to reach the Channel coast and cut off the Allied forces in Belgium. The Allies established a defensive perimeter around the **port of Dunkirk** and a remarkable escape operation was mounted. Between May 26 and June 4, 338,000 Allied troops were evacuated by sea before Dunkirk fell to the Germans.

Belgian **King Leopold III** (1901–83) **surrendered** on May 28, overruling his government's wish to continue fighting.

The French army was driven into retreat, allowing the Germans to **occupy Paris** on June 14. France was also attacked by Italy, Mussolini belatedly entering the war to pick up some of the spoils of German victory. The French government, along with much of the population, fled to the southwest. In Bordeaux, a new government was formed under the defeatist Marshal Pétain (1856–1951). **General Charles de Gaulle**, a junior minister under Reynaud and a serving army officer, escaped to Britain and

WINSTON CHURCHILL (1874–1965)

Churchill led an adventurous life as a soldier and war correspondent before entering politics. As First Lord of the Admiralty in World War I he was blamed for the Gallipoli disaster. A backbench MP during the 1930s, he opposed the appeasement of Hitler. In 1939, he returned to the Admiralty before becoming prime minister in May 1940. He led Britain through the war but lost the 1945 general election.

